THE SHIFTING LABYRINTH

Project 4: Someone Else's Mechanics, Your Story / Found

Team 3 | Story checkpoint | October 26, 2026

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Top-down 2D | Single player, two switchable explorers | Mechanics from Team 2

1. Premise | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

Trapped apart in a shifting Greek labyrinth, two explorers must reunite, defeat the Minotaur, and discover that their small owl companion is Athena, the goddess who sent them on this mission and can bring them home.

2. Beats | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

Structure: Save the Cat. Fifteen compressed beats follow separation, reunion, the path to the Minotaur, and the divine reveal.

1. Opening Image - outer labyrinth. Two explorers enter together. A small owl follows Explorer A; matching owl charms identify the pair before the walls separate them.

2. Theme Stated - split entrance paths. Paired carvings show two travelers facing a bull together: the way home depends on finding and trusting each other.

3. Setup - opposite sides of Sector 1. The player switches between explorers, learns their separated routes, and finds shrine supplies while the owl stays with Explorer A.

4. Catalyst - first shifting junctions. Moving stone walls block sight of the other explorer. Hostile Greek spirits reveal that the labyrinth is actively keeping intruders inside.

5. Debate - first shrine checkpoints. Scratched walls and abandoned armor suggest retreat, but matching footprints on the far side encourage both explorers to keep searching.

6. Break into Two - Sector 2 entrance. The explorers move deeper, using their light to hold shifting stones and fighting spirits along converging routes.

7. B Story - Sector 2 owl alcoves. The owl pauses beside ancient owl carvings; its familiar silhouette hints that the seemingly ordinary pet belongs to this place.

8. Fun and Games - divided Sector 2 routes. Switching viewpoints reveals different passages. Armor, limited supplies, wall holds, and spirit combat keep both journeys moving toward reunion.

9. Midpoint - central reunion chamber. The explorers finally meet. Hope turns to unease as both authored wall layouts channel the onward route toward enormous hoofprints.

10. Bad Guys Close In - Sector 3 approach. Light and Heavy spirits guard the inward passage. Deeper gouges, broken shields, and approaching hoofbeats announce a larger threat.

11. All Is Lost - threshold of the bull court. A final mural shows every route ending at the Minotaur. Reuniting has led them toward its lair rather than an exit.

12. Dark Night of the Soul - shrine before the arena. The paired-traveler carving appears again, intact beside shattered lone warriors. The explorers recognize that facing the beast together offers hope.

13. Break into Three - arena entrance. The reunited pair advances along the path the labyrinth has provided, preparing armor and healing relics for the final fight.

14. Finale - Minotaur arena and final shrine. The explorers defeat the Minotaur, the last Heavy enemy. At the enabled shrine, the owl transforms and reveals itself as Athena.

15. Final Image - home. Athena explains that she sent them to end the beast's reign and returns both home, together, reversing the opening separation.

3. A reason for every mechanic | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

The four received systems retain their assigned owners and recorded numerical rules. Ancient stonework, bronze gear, spectral enemies, and owl imagery replace the industrial setting.

Utility / Inventory | Michael Nearn

The explorers recover compact healing capsules and equipment left as shrine offerings by earlier travelers. Their shared ten-slot expedition satchel forces choices between backup armor and Healing Relics. Matching owl charms hint at the magical link that lets both explorers access the same supplies. Shrines serve as the established checkpoints for equipment changes; R consumes one carried healing capsule under the recorded healing rules.

Armor Types | Zion King

Light scout wraps, medium bronze equipment, and heavy guardian armor belonged to earlier challengers. Their unchanged protection and movement tradeoffs help the explorers survive restless spirits and the Minotaur. Medium armor resists the electrical attacks of some Light spirits; heavy armor prevents the existing knockback. Shared armor protects the controlled explorer. Shrine rewards and sealed stone chests retain checkpoint-reward and locker-unlock rules.

Shifting Environment | Rocky Clarke

The labyrinth is an enchanted prison whose stone partitions switch between two fixed positions every 30 seconds. The explorers' flashlight holds one light-sensitive enchanted stone for 10 seconds, followed by the existing 5-second cooldown. Both positions preserve a traversable route. After the reunion chamber, both authored layouts funnel the onward passage toward the Minotaur, making the maze itself guide the story without adding a third wall position or a new wall-moving action.

Enemy System | Kai Harris-Coles

Light and Heavy enemies appear as hostile Greek spirits bound to the labyrinth. Defeating them releases the existing shrine checkpoints and leaves recoverable equipment. The reusable weapon appears as a blessed bow firing spectral arrows, retaining the recorded damage, range, cooldown, and lack of ammunition. The Minotaur is the final Heavy enemy with the same 100 HP, 20 damage, speed 2, and 3-second attack interval; its art and sound distinguish it without adding a charge, extra phase, or third enemy class.

Two explorers and the pet - requested integration

Q switches the active explorer and camera. One shared 100-HP pool, ten-slot inventory, equipped armor state, and F/R cooldowns prevent switching from healing, duplicating supplies, or resetting timers. The inactive explorer waits, is nonblocking, and is not an enemy target. The owl follows Explorer A as a cosmetic companion. When the explorers come within one world unit in the central chamber, they reunite automatically; afterward the inactive explorer follows cosmetically. Neither follower attacks, collects items, or grants buffs.

Assignment scope: Character switching and the two-explorer reunion condition are requested additions beyond the received mechanics, not clarity guesses. They require an instructor exception under the rule against new player actions or rules. Section 5 preserves the original clarity rating; it does not claim these additions were in Team 2's handoff.

4. Found moments | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

The top-down view keeps clues on floors, low walls, and readable silhouettes. Each appears along the playable route and is discovered by looking or listening; no journal, dialogue tree, or extra inspection action is needed.

1. Matching charms and split footprints - opening junction, Sector 1

Before separation, both explorers wear the same owl-shaped charm. After the walls shift, their distinct footprints continue on opposite sides. The player learns that the goal is to find the other explorer, and that something connects them. These are background visuals, not collectible quest objects.

2. Horn scratches and hoofprints - Sector 2 convergence route

Deep paired gouges cut into the stone above human height. Broad, split hoofprints cross the smaller explorer tracks and grow more frequent toward the center. The player infers that a large horned creature inhabits the maze long before seeing the Minotaur.

3. The owl alcove - a visible recess on Explorer A's Sector 2 route

The pet rests beneath a carving of a helmeted woman and an owl; its silhouette matches the carved bird. Matching owl symbols mark the explorers' supplies. The connection foreshadows divine involvement without revealing the pet's identity through text.

4. The converging maze mural - central chamber and arena threshold

A floor pattern depicts two branching paths joining and continuing toward a bull-headed figure. After reunion, moving partitions expose the same inward route in either layout. The environment shows that the labyrinth has brought them together in order to send them to the beast.

5. Broken shields and unseen hoofbeats - Sector 3, before the arena

Discarded bronze shields bear horn-sized punctures, and slow hoofbeats sound beyond the last wall. A nearby carving shows paired travelers standing where solitary figures have fallen. The player anticipates the Minotaur and understands why reunion matters.

6. The familiar owl becomes Athena - final shrine after the Minotaur fight

After all enemies are defeated and the final shrine is reached, the owl's silhouette expands into the helmeted goddess seen in the alcove. Athena's brief speech confirms that she sent the explorers to defeat the Minotaur. A short automatic transition returns both home. The reveal and return require no extra player input.

Reunion, guidance, and ending placement

Sector 1 introduces separation; Sector 2 brings the routes to the central chamber; Sector 3 is the shared inward path and final arena. Meeting does not randomly relocate walls or create a new maze layout. The Minotaur remains the last enemy in the existing enemy-clearance sequence. Its defeat enables the final shrine; reaching it triggers the Athena reveal, return home, and victory.

5. Clarity rating | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

The four ratings and their questions and answers below are reproduced from the recorded Swap Day interpretation without changing their rules. The new setting supplies narrative and visual context. The requested character-switching and reunion additions are separately identified in Section 3; they are not retroactive changes to this clarity rating.

Utility / Inventory - HAD TO GUESS | Michael Nearn

Question: Does armor use 2/3/4 slots, or does every suit use 2?
Build answer: Use the Utility section's type-specific costs: light armor 2 slots, medium 3, heavy 4; each weapon 1 slot as an assumption; each relic 1. Capacity is exactly 10, with no upgrades. Equipped items and backup suits all occupy inventory space.

Question: Can equipment be changed outside combat, or only at checkpoints?
Build answer: Use the stricter checkpoint-only rule. Equip, switch, or voluntarily drop armor and relics only inside an activated checkpoint. Apply the same rule to weapon swaps and voluntary weapon drops. E pickups are allowed anywhere with sufficient space, and never auto-equip.

Question: What happens when a pickup will not fit?
Build answer: Reject the whole pickup, leave it in the world, and change no inventory state. No partial pickup or automatic dropping occurs. It remains available until collected or the level is restarted.

Question: What are relic effects, and how are relics used during combat?
Build answer: Healing Relics are single-use medical capsules. Each occupies one slot; duplicates do not stack. R consumes one and immediately restores 25 HP, capped at 100, with a 5-second use cooldown. Consumption is permitted during combat and outside checkpoints. At full health, without a capsule, during cooldown, or while dead, R has no effect and consumes nothing. Successful use removes exactly one capsule and frees its slot. Start with two capsules; place two more in each of the three sectors for E pickup under normal capacity rules. Collected capsules do not respawn after death. Unused capsules persist, consumed ones stay consumed, and the cooldown resets on respawn. A full level restart resets all capsules.

Checkable inventory example

A weapon (1 slot), light armor (2), a medium backup suit (3), and four capsules (4) fill all 10 slots. At 60 HP, R restores health to 85 and leaves 9 occupied slots. Another capsule can then fit. At 100 HP, R changes neither health nor inventory.

5. Clarity rating (continued) | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

Armor Types - HAD TO GUESS | Zion King

Clear rules retained: One equipped suit; no durability or maximum-health increase. Light: 15% damage reduction, +10% speed. Medium: 35% damage reduction, 25% elemental resistance. Heavy: 60% damage reduction, knockback immunity, -15% speed.

Question: How do general damage reduction and elemental resistance combine?
Build answer: Apply general reduction first, then medium armor's elemental reduction to elemental hits only. A 20-point physical hit deals 17 / 13 / 8 HP in light / medium / heavy armor. Medium armor takes 20 x 0.65 x 0.75 = 9.75 HP from a 20-point elemental hit. Retain fractional health internally.

Question: What is base movement speed, and where does elemental resistance matter?
Build answer: Base speed is 4 Godot units/second: light 4.4, medium 4, heavy 3.4. Some Light enemies deal electrical damage while retaining their 10 damage, 2-unit attack range, and 1.5-second attack interval. All other attacks are physical. This adds a damage type to existing enemies, not a separate hazard or player action.

Question: What does knockback immunity prevent?
Build answer: Ordinary hits move the player 0.5 unit away from the attacker, stopped by collision. Heavy armor prevents that displacement. Knockback causes no extra damage or stun.

Question: When does combat end, and does that allow an armor swap?
Build answer: Combat ends when no enemy is pursuing or attacking the player. Swapping still requires an activated checkpoint. Checkpoints cannot activate during combat; entering one during combat enables neither activation nor swapping.

Question: How do death and backup armor interact with inventory?
Build answer: At zero HP, lose the attempt and respawn at the latest checkpoint with 100 HP and the same equipped suit. Remove every unequipped backup suit from inventory and place it at the death location. Retain weapons and relics; recovery of dropped suits requires E and enough free space.

Question: Are locked lockers or miniboss rewards required?
Build answer: Keep all three armor sources. Spawn one armor reward at each newly activated checkpoint. Security lockers unlock when all enemies in their sector are defeated. Selected Heavy enemies serve as elite minibosses with unchanged Heavy stats and a guaranteed armor drop. All armor requires E and sufficient capacity. No keys, lockpicking action, or third enemy type is added.

5. Clarity rating (continued) | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

Shifting Environment - HAD TO GUESS | Rocky Clarke

Clear rules retained: Every 30 seconds, eligible objects attempt to switch between two fixed positions at most 5 feet apart. F freezes one aimed-at object within 10 feet for 10 seconds; only one freeze exists. A 5-second cooldown follows. A thawed object waits for a global shift. Objects cannot damage, overlap, or fully trap the player.

Question: How do feet translate to the enemy system's units?
Build answer: One Godot unit equals one meter. Maximum shift is 1.524 units; flashlight range is 3.048 units. Enemy detection / attack / leash ranges stay 6 / 2 / 10 units.

Question: What if a shift overlaps the player or seals every route?
Build answer: Check collision and a remaining walkable route before each change. Skip unsafe changes until the next global 30-second event. Both authored layouts and reachable mixed frozen layouts must leave an escape route. Apply player-clearance checks to respawn placement too.

Question: Can freeze be refreshed, and what happens at an exact timer boundary?
Build answer: No refresh or retargeting until the 10-second freeze and 5-second cooldown finish. F requires line of sight and ignores invalid targets. At a shared timestamp: process expirations, then valid F inputs, then the shift. A newly thawed object may shift at that event; a newly frozen object may not. Cooldown prevents immediate re-freezing.

Enemy System - HAD TO GUESS | Kai Harris-Coles

Clear rules retained: Light: 50 HP, 10 damage, speed 4, attacks every 1.5 seconds. Heavy: 100 HP, 20 damage, speed 2, attacks every 3 seconds. Both detect within 6 units, attack within 2, stop pursuit beyond 10 units from their starting position, navigate around walls, and drop one weapon or armor item on defeat. Clear every enemy to advance.

Question: What weapon, damage, range, and starting health does the player have?
Build answer: Start at 100 HP with an equipped reusable weapon: 25 damage, 0.5-second attack cooldown, 10-unit range, no ammunition. Left click fires at the first collision under the aim point; walls block shots. Starting light armor and two Healing Relics bring starting occupancy to 5 slots. A Light enemy takes two hits; a Heavy takes four.

Question: Can enemies detect or attack through walls, and what survives death?
Build answer: Detection and attacks require line of sight. The first attack waits the stated interval; subsequent attacks repeat at that interval while valid. Leashed enemies return to their starting positions without healing. Player death preserves defeated enemies, remaining enemy HP, uncollected drops, and activated checkpoints. Restart resets these.

Question: What exactly are victory, defeat, and checkpoint behavior?
Build answer: Use three encounters. Defeating all enemies in an encounter enables the next checkpoint. Walking into it activates it, allows progress and equipment changes, and spawns its one-time armor reward. Reaching the final checkpoint after every enemy is defeated wins. Zero HP loses the attempt and triggers checkpoint respawn. Checkpoint activation does not heal; only relic use and respawning restore health as defined above.

6. Text | Author: Rocklyn Clarke

This is the complete planned text and speech. No environmental inscriptions use readable words: clues are images, footprints, scratches, props, and sounds. Inventory labels appear once in a fixed legend; item slots and pickups use icons. Athena has the only spoken dialogue, with no duplicate subtitles.

Placement	Exact text or speech	Words
Active-character labels	Explorer A	2
Active-character labels	Explorer B	2
HUD health-bar label	Health	1
HUD inventory-capacity label	Slots	1
Inventory panel heading	Inventory	1
Fixed inventory legend	Light Armor	2
Fixed inventory legend	Medium Armor	2
Fixed inventory legend	Heavy Armor	2
Fixed inventory legend	Weapon	1
Fixed inventory legend	Healing Relic	2
Final enemy health-bar label	Minotaur	1
Athena, at final shrine	I am Athena. I sent you here to end the Minotaur's reign. You found each other. Now I will bring you home.	22
Victory screen	Home, together.	2
Defeat / respawn overlay	Lost, but not forgotten.	4

Counted total: 45 words out of 150. Environmental writing: 0. Character labels, HUD, inventory, and boss label: 17. Athena's speech: 22. Result screens: 6. No other labels, written notifications, or numeric readouts are planned. Health, occupancy, and cooldowns use bars, slot icons, and fill indicators.

Excluded title, menu buttons, and controls screen

Title: The Shifting Labyrinth (3 words).
Menu buttons: Play, Restart, Controls, Back, Quit (5 words total).

Controls screen - exact lines:
Move: W A S D (5)
Aim: Mouse (2)
Fire: Left Click (3)
Pick up: E (3)
Hold wall: F (3)
Heal: R (2)
Inventory: Tab (2)
Switch explorer: Q (3)
At shrine, select equipment: Left Click (6)
At shrine, drop selected item: X (6)
Pause: Escape (2)

Controls screen: 37 words. Excluded text: 45 words. All planned words including exclusions: 90. Counts use whitespace-separated words. Only the title, menu buttons, and key-binding controls screen are excluded from the 150-word cap.